

Will November 19, 2023, be another historic day in the annals of Indian cricket like June 25, 1983, and April 2, 2011, were? Will Rohit Sharma joyously lift the ICC World Cup over his head like Kapil Dev and Mahendra Singh Dhoni did on those two iconic days? Will another glorious chapter be written to inspire future generations of cricketers to try and emulate these memorable feats? After the demolition of Pakistan and Sri Lanka in the recently concluded Asia Cup, Indian cricket fans are entitled to believe that, yes, the team under its captain Rohit Sharma will add another World Cup to the trophy cabinet of the BCCI.

Casting a glance at the Indian squad, one will find that the batting line-up is such that it will give sleepless nights to all the bowlers of all opponents. While the skipper hasn't quite hit peak form as yet, he holds the record for the highest individual score in ODIs—264 at Eden Gardens in 2014—where he got out after being caught on the boundary to the last ball of the final over. His opening partner Shubman Gill has already gone past 1,000 runs in ODIs this year and bids fair to get close to the 2,000-run mark by the time the year ends. What has been impressive about the talented young man is his quick assessment of the situation and adjusting his game to address it. Like Virat Kohli who, too, is in red-hot form, Gill doesn't need to resort to the unorthodox shots that are the signature tunes of Suryakumar Yadav and Ishan Kishan.

The classical correctness of K.L. Rahul and the swashbuckling ways of Shreyas Iyer and Hardik Pandya can cause mayhem with the opposition. With the super-confident Ravindra Jadeja to finish things off, the Indian batting looks formidable indeed.

The bowling, too, has got an added edge with the return of Jasprit Bumrah. Whether India will go with the two Mohammeds—Shami and Siraj—will depend to a great extent on where the match is and who the opposition will be. The spin department will be in the hands of the experienced Jadeja and the wiles of Kuldeep Yadav. Shardul Thakur and Axar Patel will provide bulk to the lower order and also help fulfil the fifth bowler's role.

The 1983 and 2011 teams were blessed with an abundance of all-rounders, which eased the burden on the captain considerably. Sharma also has Hardik Pandya, Jadeja, Patel and Thakur, with the latter two perhaps fighting for a place in the XI. Like the '83 and 2011 teams, this will also be a top fielding unit, with Jadeja unquestionably the best in the game today.

Their main stumbling blocks will be the defending champions England, who over the past few years have taken one-day cricket to another level, and Australia, who are always a force to reckon with. Their strength is the number of game-changing all-rounders they have. South Africa will be high on confidence with their recent comeback win against Australia after being two matches down at the start of the five-match ODI series. They have been dealt a big blow with the injury to Anrich Nortje who will thus miss his second consecutive World Cup.

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New Zealand as always will fly under the radar and cause more than a few surprises. They are still sweating over the fitness of their captain, Kane Williamson, and the experienced seamer Tim Southee. Afghanistan, too, are capable of an upset or two if their batting clicks. Bangladesh disappointed in the Asia Cup but will be high on confidence after beating India, albeit without its top players. Whether Sri Lanka can lift themselves up after the humiliating loss in the Asia Cup finals will determine their progress in the World Cup.

As always, Pakistan will be the danger team. Even when we played against them years ago, the fighting and the bitching among their players, and often on the field itself, was amusing, to say the least. But when the bowler started his run-up, they would amazingly get totally focused on the job. In Babar Azam, they have one of the finest batsmen the game has seen and he will be the key for Pakistan with his batting and his leadership.

India have both the home advantage and knowledge of the pitches and the conditions. Their massive crowd support at every venue can sometimes be disturbing and disconcerting to the opposition. The previous three World Cups have been won by the countries hosting the matches. Over a billion hearts and lips will be praying for India to continue that tradition and make November 19 another unforgettable day in its cricket story. ■

Sunil Gavaskar was part of the legendary 1983 World Cup squad and is recognised as one of the greatest batsmen. He is also a respected commentator